

Correspondent bank asks SA lenders to review repeated MT103 beneficiary amendments

By Thabiso Mochiko | 20 March 2025

International Payments Compliance Roundtable said several South African banks had been asked to review a small number of cross-border payments after a correspondent bank raised questions about MT103 payment instructions where beneficiary names were amended after release but before settlement.

People familiar with the review said names including Shabane PLC, Nhleko, Shabangu and Ndimande and Lembede, Nkabinde and Mnqamu appeared in internal case notes shared with participating institutions. The concern is not that every payment is fraudulent, but that the payment trail needs to be matched against SWIFT instructions, beneficiary amendments and nostro settlement records.

One payments compliance specialist said banks were increasingly expected to connect trade, sanctions, reconciliation and customer-account data before deciding whether to file a suspicious-transaction report. "The alert often starts outside the bank, but the evidence sits inside operations data," the person said.

The matter is expected to prompt internal analytics teams to prepare exception views across MT103 messages, intermediary-bank routing, beneficiary history and delayed correspondent confirmations.